

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Mirza Jibraan Taimuri

Address: 60 Salisbury Avenue Cheam SM1 2DJ

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am writing to express my strong support for the proposal to convert the dormant ambulance station into a mosque and community facility. This project represents a thoughtful approach to urban renewal, transforming an underutilized, deteriorating asset into a vibrant center for social and spiritual cohesion.

1. Social Impact & Community Inclusivity

The primary driver for this support is the urgent need for adequate space. Currently, local demand for prayer and community services far outstrips the capacity of existing infrastructure.

Relieving Infrastructure Stress: Existing facilities are frequently over-capacity, leading to cramped conditions that hinder the quality of worship and community engagement.

Support for Vulnerable Groups: Crucially, this additional square footage is not just about numbers; it is about dignity and safety. For children with sensory vulnerabilities, neurodivergent conditions, or physical disabilities, "cramped" environments can be overwhelming or inaccessible.

A Safe Haven: The proposed layout allows for dedicated, quieter spaces. This ensures that vulnerable community members-and those with underlying health conditions-can participate in communal life without the physical stress and health risks associated with overcrowded environments.

2. Domestic & Local Amenity Benefits

A common concern with any conversion is the impact on the immediate neighbourhood. This

proposal proactively addresses these issues:

Dedicated Off-Street Parking: By incorporating on-site parking, the plan mitigates the risk of street congestion. This is a significant improvement over the current "dormant" state, which often attracts unauthorized parking or anti-social behaviour.

Managed Use: Unlike the unpredictable sirens and high-intensity activity of an active emergency station, a community center operates on a predictable schedule, offering a more harmonious "neighbour" to local residents.

3. Economic Vitality & Urban Regeneration

Leaving a public building dormant is an economic drain on the area. Bringing it back into use provides several financial upsides:

Asset Preservation: Regular maintenance and private investment will prevent the building from falling into further disrepair, which protects the property values of the surrounding area.

Local Spending: The presence of a community hub brings footfall to local businesses and services, providing a subtle but consistent "micro-economic" boost to nearby shops.

Job Creation: The construction phase and the subsequent facility management offer opportunities for local employment and volunteerism.

4 Enhanced Traffic & Local Synergy Strategy

Strategic Alignment with 'The Avenue' School A key strength of this proposal is its proactive approach to local traffic management and its relationship with nearby educational institutions.

Mitigating Peak-Hour Congestion: The management of the proposed mosque has committed to a flexible scheduling model. Where religiously permissible, prayer times and community events have been strategically adjusted to avoid overlap with the drop-off and pick-up windows of The Avenue school. This "staggered" approach ensures that the local road network is not overwhelmed, maintaining a smooth flow of traffic for parents, residents, and commuters alike.

Cultural and Practical Synergy: It is worth noting that 'The Avenue' already demonstrates an inclusive ethos by catering to Halal dietary requirements. This indicates a significant overlap between the school's demographic and the mosque's congregation. By providing a place of worship within walking distance of an institution that already serves these families, we reduce the need for multi-trip car journeys, encouraging a "park once" or "walk-to-both" culture.

Improving Safety for Vulnerable Students: As 'The Avenue' serves a diverse student body, the reduction in street-side congestion directly contributes to a safer environment for children. Combined with the mosque's transition to off-street parking, this proposal represents a net improvement in pedestrian safety compared to the current unmanaged state of the dormant station.

Conclusion

The conversion of this site is a "common-sense" solution to a pressing social problem. It takes a site that is currently serving no purpose and repurposes it to serve the most vulnerable among us- providing a spacious, safe, and modern environment for children and adults alike.

I urge the planning committee to recognize the multifaceted benefits of this application and grant approval for this much-needed community resource.